Consider this:

- Netflix credits over 80% of watched content to AI recommendations.
- Google processes billions of AI-assisted searches daily, many never reaching a human-curated result.
- Social media platforms optimise engagement using reinforcement learning—often amplifying outrage because it retains attention better than calm reasoning.

Notably, AI is not just taking over the functions of humans, but it is also quietly taking the place of the layer of society that influences decisions.

Productivity boom or human skill bust?

Advocates of AI tell us that there are already considerable gains in productivity—and they do not lie. Consultancy companies like McKinsey and PwC predict that AI will be a US$ 15 trillion addition to the world economy by 2030. Programmers who rely on AI coding assistants claim that their output has increased by 20-40%. The elimination of human involvement in customer service reduces problem resolution times to a matter of seconds. However, this is not without a downside.

The upswing in productivity is not equally shared, and the development of skilled workers is no longer a gradual process. The moment AI does a task quicker and with higher quality, the human is very likely to stop doing that task.

The introduction of spell-checker caused people to rely less on their spelling ability. The same happened with satellite navigation systems and people's capacity to find their way around. Now that generative AI has made headway in writing, coding, design, and analysis, it might extinguish the very skills that are categorised as 'knowledge work'. The important question: If machines are thinking, what is the job of humans in the training process?

Every technological era comes with the promise of reskilling. This is supported by history—newly created positions took the place of old ones during the industrial revolution. But AI comes with a fundamental change. What's being phased out is brains rather than brawn. The not-so-white-collar professions that were regarded safe—accounting, journalism, law, software engineering—are being reshaped. Entry-level positions that have traditionally been used for developing expertise are disappearing the fastest.

Once a junior analyst learned via reports. Now, AI takes that over. A junior developer learned through debugging. Now, AI repairs the code before the human comprehends the mistake. How do you develop new skills when the learning ladder is taken away? This is not the same as just losing a job—it is losing the ability to gather experience.

Why startups love AI

For entrepreneurs, AI is difficult to resist. A startup today can run with just a small part of the workforce that was required ten years ago. AI manages the customer service, creates marketing copy, does analytics, coding, and even comes up with new product ideas.

From a business perspective, this is logical: AI does not ask for salaries, leaves, or benefits. It can be scaled up instantly, and improves with data, not with experience.

However, this also triggers a situation where humans are considered expensive bottlenecks. The startup ecosystem is, in fact, addressing the all-important question: How much human presence is needed in an enterprise?

Large enterprises: Opting for efficiency over empathy

For large companies, AI heralds the era of efficiency and cost-cutting. Boards are authorising AI adoption since shareholders demand dividends. However, automated decision systems are denying loans, rejecting candidates, or optimising layoffs. Who holds the responsibility? Is it the algorithm, the vendor, or the executive who signed the contract?

AI is being deployed by most large enterprises quicker than they can comprehend it. Ethical reviews are carried out only after the deployment of the product. Governance practices have not caught up with the pace of innovation. The focus is on efficiency at the expense of empathy, and society may suffer the consequences in the long run.

When algorithms decide what you see, buy, and believe

Cognitive shaping is one of the most underestimated impacts of AI. The algorithms determine:

- What trends in the news
- Which voices are louder
- Which opinions are more common

Gradually, this results in the creation of algorithmic reality tunnels that are fortifying beliefs and polarising societies. AI is not trying to deceive; however, it optimises for engagement and not for truth. The more advanced machines become, the less humans will think critically and just trust the outputs without questioning the assumptions made. Curiosity will slowly be replaced by convenience.

Are we outsourcing thinking itself?

This is probably the most perilous trend of all. AI is already performing tasks like email drafting, document summarisation, and essay writing. The role of humans is continually becoming that of reviewers and not of thinkers. Mental muscles do weaken over time due to lack of usage. In the cognitive world, outsourcing leads to intellectual dependence. The issue is not whether AI is thinking but whether humans are choosing not to.